WHAT IT TAKES TO BE **A WINNER**

How Manu trained for different aspects of her sport



A RICH HAUL Manu displays the medals at her Faridabad home

@bhakermanu/Instagram

STRENGTH, ENDURANCE, CALMNESS: It required her to spend hours at the range, standing still in one place and repeating the drill of raising the gun and aiming for the target

HAND-EYE COORDINATION: An essential component of the sport, it entails a seamless flow between mind, muscle, eye and the nervous system. Manu limits her screen time to preserve focus and sight. Between shots, she keeps the process in mind, breathing patterns in check and channelises thought

STABILITY: This requires strong core muscles including of the abdomen and spine, besides limbs, the finger flexor and deltoids. Manu loves her time in the gym, doing stretches, weight and strength training, core workout and rehabilitation, particularly of the elbow and scapula

MENTAL PERSEVERANCE: Since scoring in the sport is by elimination, stress is a constant for shooters. You have to manage both your nerves and the heart rate. Yoga and meditation are part of Manu's daily training routine; she even meditates before sleep

MOTIVATION: A coach's role is crucial in this. Manu recalls how Jaspal Rana would play the "guilty card", telling her how missing training or taking a day off could prove costly come competition time and the need to value her spot as there's always someone gunning for it

spends at the gym in their building in Faridabad. Her workout buddy-cum-3 am friend Supratik Chhaperia a.k.a. Super, tells us how Manu can knock him down even when sparring in jest. "*Bahut zyaada jaan hai ismein* [She has a lot of strength]," says the 30-year-old Chhaperia. Shooting is something they deliberately keep out of their conversations, but it's a side he cannot escape. "*Movie dekhte waqt bhi* [even while watching a movie], most of the time she is holding (the posture of holding a pistol)," he says. Chhaperia credits her for her "grit". "Good or bad training or match, she gets upset, but moves forward and thinks about how to improve. She is too 'present', that's something I've learnt from her," he says.

THE NEW NATIONAL CRUSH

While the glory of her Olympics achievements has yet to subside, Manu is already dealing with another kind of fame—of being India's new 'national crush' or 'it girl'. Her Instagram following has soared from 150,000 to 1.7 million post her Parisian exploits. From one brand, she is now endorsing seven. The past few months, she has been seen skydiving in Dubai, walking the ramp at a fashion show in Delhi and voting in the Haryana election. She seems at ease dressing up and posing for the camera; you only have to follow her on Insta to see how *au courant* she is with the latest sartorial trends. "I am creative with my outfits," she says. "Sometimes it does feel like work, but I try to enjoy everything." With P.V. Sindhu's career on the wane, a nation starved of non-cricketing sporting icons has found its poster girl in Manu, a mantle she wears readily.

The ongoing Manu fever has also meant it's the longest she has been away from the sport. Fame and success can also be sources of distraction. Rana knows he has to protect his protégé. "Some are not able to digest the money or celebrity status they get. If a talented athlete is getting out of control, it is our responsibility to help them. I will do my best to keep her on her toes and grounded, but it is not entirely my work," he says, adding that parents also play an important role.

At Vivanta Surajkund in Faridabad, as Manu wraps up the shoot and interview, her second of the day, Anantjeet Singh Naruka, a shotgun shooter preparing for the ongoing ISSF World Cup in New Delhi, asks how she has been. "Sleep-deprived but good," Manu tells him, adding that she's itching to get back to the range. Days later, she shares an Insta story with her picture at the range. "I really love and enjoy my sport. It's when I feel most alive," she says. India should be relieved that Manu has her sights set on the target. Hopefully, it stays so till Los Angeles 2028. And maybe even till India 2036. ■